



Pi can appear in surprising places. Think of a long, winding river that snakes across a flat plain to the sea, like the Amazon or the Mississippi. If you measure the length of the river and divide it by the distance as the crow flies from source to sea, the answer is close to pi. And not a circle in sight!

Every phone number
in the *world* appears
among the decimal
places of pi

FOREVER AND EVER

As well as being infinitely long, pi's decimal places are totally random, with no mathematical pattern whatsoever. That means that the string of numbers contains, somewhere along it, every phone number in the world. And if you converted the numbers to letters, you'd find every book that's ever been written or will be written.



FAQ

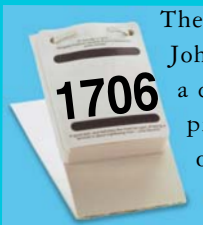
What use is pi?

Pi is incredibly useful to scientists, engineers, and designers. Anything circular (like a can of beans) and anything that moves in circles (like a wheel or a planet) involves pi. Without pi, people wouldn't be able to build cars, understand how planets move, or work out how many baked beans fit in a can.

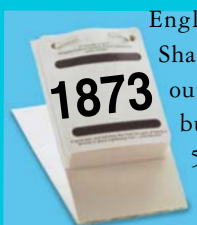
Did you know?

In 1897 the State of Indiana, USA, tried to pass a law decreeing that pi is exactly 3.2. They wanted everyone in the world to use their value of pi and pay them a royalty, which would have earned millions. But just before the bill was passed, a mathematician pointed out that it was complete nonsense, and so the State Senate dropped it.

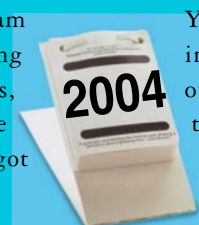
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The English astronomer John Machin discovered a complicated formula for pi and used it to work out the first 100 decimal places.



English mathematician William Shanks spent 15 years working out pi to 707 decimal places, but he made an error at the 528th decimal place and got all the rest wrong. Oops!



Yasumasa Kanada in Tokyo worked out pi on a computer to 1.24 trillion decimal places.